

A Crash Course in Civic Hellraising

How to Make Your Reps Listen (Even When They'd Rather Ignore You)



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Tired of politicians treating you like background noise? Time to use their own rules against them. [Sunshine Laws](#) exist so government meetings can't happen in the shadows—and that means **you** have the right to show up, speak up, and make them squirm in their seats!

Inspired by [Operation Sunshine's Guide for Speaking at Local Government Meetings](#),¹ here's your crash course in civic hellraising:

Step 1: Crash the Right Party

City councils, school boards, county commissions—these are the rooms where real decisions get made. **By law**, they have to tell you when and where they're meeting. Look it up on their website, a newspaper notice, or just call and ask (then enjoy the awkward silence when they realize you know your rights).

Bonus tip: Sit in on a meeting before speaking so you know who's who and how the game is played.

Step 2: Prep Like a Pro

- **Know Your Opponents:** Who's on the board? What do they care about? What donors do they care about? If you can connect your issue to their interests (or re-election odds), you're golden.
- **Know the Rules:** Meetings have public comment rules—time limits, sign-up requirements, and, yes, you can usually record them (but double-check).
- **Script It & Cut the Fluff:** You get maybe 1-3 minutes to make your case, so get to the damn point. Personal stories hit hardest.
- **Expect the Dodge:** They will try to brush you off. Be ready with a follow-up.
Step 3: Show Up & Speak Out
- **Call Your Shot:** Before the meeting, post:
"I'm speaking at [meeting] about [issue]. What should I ask? Drop your questions—I'll report back."
The more people you claim to represent, the harder they'll listen.
- **Record Everything:** Have a friend film you (and their reactions). If they try to shut you down, congratulations—you're now the main character of local politics.
- **Deliver Your Mic Drop Moment:** Speak with confidence, **do not let them rush you**, and if they try to deflect, call it out.

Step 4: Make It Stick

- **Follow Up:** Email your statement to the officials, local press, and social media.
- **Stay Loud:** If they ignore you? Show up again. And again. They work for **you**, not the other way around.

Why This Works

Because they count on you being too busy, too polite, or too discouraged to show up. Prove them wrong. Use the Sunshine Laws. Take up space. Make them uncomfortable. And when they try to ignore you? **Make. Them. Regret. It.**

Ready? Go Be loud. Be bold. Be *American!*

- *Lady Libertie*

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